Game rivals with jealousy. In November 1918, for example, Cox informed the Foreign Office that Minorskii had been causing a nuisance to the British during his tour of northern Persia.[74] *British military personnel, in turn, viewed the Russians with barely disguised contempt.*[75] *By December, CIGS was forced to instruct Malleson to warn his officers in Persia to refrain from openly showing hostility towards the Russian Legation.*[76]

For, despite Russia's weakness in 1918, Britain could not afford to aggravate Minorskii and Staroselskii. For one thing, having been appointed by the Russian Provisional Government, Minorskii was able to disassociate himself from the days of imperial Russian rule in Persia, and represent himself as a progressive liberal, making his standing among the Persian public relatively high.[77] Another problem lay in the fact that 'the mere consideration that they depend on us for their up-keep counts for nothing when Russian interests or those of the Division lie in a direction contrary to those of His Majesty's Government'.[78] This meant that, should they feel the urge to do so, the Russian leaders in Persia could quite simply turn on their benefactors and, while Britain could probably easily put down such a rebellion, it had no wish to incite such a situation. For one thing, the Cossack Division remained a useful resource in the face of any civil unrest or to be employed against any possible Bolshevik incursion into Persia. The division's influence over the shah was also formidable. As Curzon noted, 'the Russian commander of the brigade, Starosselski [sic] was, owing to the size of his force and his easy access to the Shah, dictator of the situation, and, until the circumstances were more favourable to ourselves, it would be impolitic to arouse his enmity.'[79] Nine months earlier, in April 1918, when trying to convince the British government to continue financially supporting the Russian Legation, Marling had warned that without the money, the legation and consulates would be forced to close, and that 'if [the Russian] Minister himself left I am convinced Persian Government would eventually recognise such people as Bravine [sic]'.[80]

In December 1918, Marling continued to argue that, were Russian influence to be eliminated completely from northern Persia, it would create a vacuum and if Britain was unable to fill this vacuum itself, it would 'prove very tempting to some other Power'. While Germany or Turkey perhaps no longer represented a threat, there still remained the possibility of